Though Humayun brought only a small force with him into Hindustan, the composition of its nobility was unique. Of the fifty-one nobles listed as having joined his forces by 1555, twenty-seven were identified as Turani, often high-ranked, and sixteen were Shia Persians, or Iranis,* usually lower ranked. ‘Before this,’ writes historian Iqtidar Alam Khan, ‘in no state ruled by a Muslim dynasty did Shi’as and Sunnis coexist in the nobility in such remarkable amity’.

As Humayun settled into Delhi, the young Akbar continued to be fascinated by the animals he discovered around him. He killed a nilgai with a sword and was enchanted by a cheetah which was presented to him by a nobleman who had captured it at the battle of Machhiwara†. The cheetah’s keeper, Dundu, was given the title Fath Khan and Akbar spent many happy hours with this animal and his keeper. Humayun and Akbar also spent some time together painting under the guidance of the two great Persian master artists, Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd al-Samad. One of Akbar’s tenacious memories of Humayun, vibrant even half a century later, would appear to be intimately linked to his love of paintings. ‘My father esteemed much things like this,’ he would say to a Jesuit priest about a beautiful image of the Virgin Mary in 1602, ‘and if anyone had given it him, he would have granted him any boon he might have asked.’ There is an exquisite miniature that survives from this early Mughal taswir khana that might depict these precise moments. In a painting filled with swirling movement entitled ‘Prince Akbar presents a painting to his father Humayun’, the miniature depicts that evanescent hour between end of day and beginning of night. The evening’s entertainment is about to begin after a day spent hunting and a young Akbar presents a painting to his father, who eagerly bends forward. The image being presented is in fact *that very painting* and Kavita Singh postulates that Akbar might have contributed to it along with the master Abd al-Samad. Singh also points out that ‘the range of colours used suggests that it was made in a well-stocked studio, and the meticulous finish is the result of laborious and time-consuming processes of layering and burnishing the surface’. The library depicted in the miniature may even be the Sher Mandal, the two-storey pavilion in the Deenpanah* (Asylum of Faith), where Humayun housed his precious books and manuscripts.

Four months later, Humayun decided to send Akbar north as governor to the crucial and turbulent region of the Punjab. Since Munim Khan was still in Kabul, Akbar was now assigned a new ataliq, Bairam Khan, and the